Northbank Libraries

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A letter from the director

In 2025 Northbank's seven branch libraries had their busiest year since the network was formed in 1998. Visits rose to 1.42 million, up 18 percent on 2024. I want to explain what changed, what it cost, and where we fell short. Director Priya Raman.

Opening hours

In April we extended weekday hours at all seven branches from 6 pm to 9 pm. We paid for it by moving 22 staff from back-office cataloguing, which we now share with the county system, to the front desk. Evening visits went from 9 percent of all visits to 24 percent. The evening hours cost $310,000 a year in extra building and security costs.

Fines

We stopped charging late fines on 1 January 2025. Fines had brought in $86,000 in 2024. We expected some books to come back later, and some did: the average loan now returns 2.1 days later than before. But 3,900 people whose accounts had been blocked by unpaid fines came back and borrowed again, and lost-item losses fell by 11 percent because people were no longer afraid to return overdue books.

Lending things, not only books

The "library of things" started at two branches in March and spread to all seven by September. Members can now borrow 640 items, including sewing machines, telescopes, power drills and laptops. Those items were borrowed 12,700 times in 2025. Laptops were the most borrowed item, followed by the carpet cleaner.

Digital lending

E-book and audiobook loans reached 410,000, up 31 percent. Licences for digital titles cost us $1.9 million, which is 34 percent of our collection budget for 22 percent of our loans. Publishers charge libraries several times the consumer price for an e-book licence, and many licences expire after two years. We are lobbying the state for a fair-pricing law and will report on it next year.

Where we fell short

The Eastgate branch roof repair ran five months late and closed the branch for 14 weeks in the summer, when children's programs are busiest. Our summer reading program reached 5,200 children, below our target of 6,500, mostly because of the Eastgate closure. We also missed our goal of a mobile library van; the van was ordered but will not arrive until mid-2026.

Money

Item	2025
Total budget	$14.6 million
Collections (books, digital, things)	$5.6 million
Staff	$7.1 million
Buildings and evening hours	$1.9 million

The budget is 4 percent higher than in 2024. Cost per visit fell from $11.80 to $10.30 because visits grew faster than spending.

2026 plans

We will open Sunday afternoons at three branches, start the mobile library van in the rural north once it arrives, and add 200 items to the library of things, chosen by member vote.